

28-Day Plant Stabilization Schedule (Primary Advisory)

Purpose: This document defines the survival-critical and establishment-critical care logic for the first 28 days after purchase or planting. It is designed as a conservative, agent-readable reference. Category-specific PDFs provide additional nuance but must not contradict this baseline.

Global Guardrails (Always Enforced – P1)

- 1 Plant only when soil is workable (not frozen, not waterlogged).
- 2 Water based on soil/root-zone moisture, not on the calendar.
- 3 Avoid quick-release fertilizer at planting or during heat/drought stress.
- 4 Pause irrigation after heavy rain; standing water beyond ~24 hours is a drainage failure.
- 5 If advice conflicts: survival rules override optimization advice.

Day 0 (Planting Day) – P1

- 1 Plant at correct depth (root flare or crown at soil surface unless species-specific guidance says otherwise).
- 2 Eliminate air pockets; ensure firm soil-root contact.
- 3 Water in thoroughly until the entire root ball and surrounding soil are saturated.
- 4 Apply mulch 2–3 inches deep where appropriate; keep mulch off stems/crowns.
- 5 Do NOT fertilize at planting unless a labeled starter solution is explicitly recommended.

Days 1–7 (Acute Establishment Window) – P1

- 1 Check soil moisture daily; water deeply whenever the root zone begins to dry.
- 2 Containers may require multiple moisture checks per day in heat or wind.
- 3 Avoid shallow, frequent sprinkling; water at the base.
- 4 Provide temporary shade or wind protection if plants wilt during extreme conditions.
- 5 Do not prune except for dead or broken tissue.

Days 8–14 (Early Root Expansion) – P1 / P2

- 1 Continue frequent moisture checks; many plants still require daily or every-other-day watering.
- 2 Allow slight surface drying between waterings, but never allow the root ball to dry out.
- 3 Inspect for early pest pressure (aphids, mites, slugs); intervene conservatively.
- 4 Avoid fertilizing unless plants are actively growing AND soil/media was not pre-fertilized.

Days 15–21 (Stabilization Phase) – P2

- 1 Begin extending time between waterings if soil moisture remains stable.
- 2 Water deeply; avoid reverting to shallow watering.
- 3 Light, dilute feeding may be considered ONLY if growth is active and conditions are mild.
- 4 Continue weed suppression to reduce competition for water.

Days 22–28 (Transition to Establishment) – P2

- 1 Shift from daily checks to weather-responsive monitoring.
- 2 Water when soil begins to dry at depth; avoid calendar-only schedules.
- 3 Do not increase fertilizer rates; overfeeding during early establishment causes long-term stress.
- 4 Remove temporary supports/shade gradually if used.

Weather & Seasonal Overrides (Always P1)

- 1 Heat waves: increase watering frequency; provide temporary shade; suspend fertilization.
- 2 Cold snaps/frost: protect tender plants; water beforehand only if soil is dry and above freezing.
- 3 Heavy rain: stop irrigation; ensure drainage; pull mulch back if soil remains wet.
- 4 Winter dry periods (evergreens): water on mild days if soil is not frozen.

Failure Signals vs Normal Adjustment – P1

- 1 Normal: mild wilting immediately after planting that recovers after watering; temporary leaf drop.
- 2 Warning: persistent wilt with wet soil, stem collapse, progressive browning or blackening.
- 3 Action: treat wet-soil wilt as drainage failure, not drought.

Operationalization Notes (For Product Implementation)

- 1 Add machine-readable tokens (e.g., DAY_RANGE, PRIORITY, OVERRIDE_TYPE) to each rule for deterministic parsing.
- 2 Map this baseline directly to rule objects; category-specific logic may narrow but must not violate P1 guardrails.
- 3 Validate this baseline with extension faculty before locking v1 as a source-of-truth artifact.

End of primary stabilization window. After Day 28, transition to category-specific guidance and long-term care rules.